Faster, Higher, Stronger

A few other Paris Olympics contenders from India



ALAMY

Vinesh Phogat

It's now evident that Vinesh Phogat is made of sterner stuff, both on the mat and off it. Most of last year, she was taking on an errant wrestling federation, even sleeping out in the streets and dealing with the threats and derision hurled at her. At the Asian Olympic qualifier in April, she dropped weight overnight to be eligible for her category. The following day, she dismantled her opponents, making the Olympic qualification seem like a cakewalk. She's taken on fights of all kinds in the recent past, and is sure to be battle-ready come July.



Manu Bhaker

For Manu Bhaker, it's taken a while to let go of the past and look ahead. The shooter had entered the Tokyo Olympics in 2021 as the World No. 1, but drew a blank. There on, the results continued to elude her and it wasn't until the World Cup in Bhopal last year that she was back on the podium in an individual capacity. Reuniting with coach Jaspal Rana has done wonders. At the first round of the Olympics selection trial in New Delhi, she smashed the world record in the 25m pistol event. Rest assured, if she makes the team, Bhaker will be raring to go.

Nikhat Zareen

Over the last couple of years, boxer Nikhat Zareen has made rapid progress. It started with the world championships gold in 2022, a title she defended the following year. In between the two, she landed another gold on her Commonwealth Games debut in Birmingham. A bronze at the Hangzhou Asian Games last year sealed Zareen's spot at the Paris Olympics. For long, she's battled the odds under the shadow of MC Mary Kom. Her time has finally come.



Neeraj Chopra



AP

There's an unsaid pressure that comes with the tag of defending champion. Neeraj Chopra experienced it at the Asian Games in Hangzhou last year, where he hurled a season's best throw of 88.88 metres to successfully defend his crown. As the athletics season gets under way in May, he'll expect more of the same at the Doha Diamond League, where he took top spot in 2023. And then at the Paris Olympics in July, where he has a shot at creating history by becoming the first Indian to land back-to-back individual gold medals.

Satwiksairaj Rankireddy & Chirag Shetty

In October 2023, the duo became the first Indian pair to be ranked World No. 1. By the end of the year, they had won three titles, besides the first gold at the Asian Games and Asian Championships. Then last month, they set a new benchmark for Indian badminton after holding on to the World No. 1 spot for 10 consecutive weeks. Going by their performance, there are certainly more firsts in store for these two. Perhaps one at the Olympics as well.

–Shail Desai

